



Reviewing Your Current Curriculum (Learner Roles)

What is a learner role? According to Serafini (2012) while engaging with a learning experience, learners take on *four specific roles* as they try to make meaning of the content in a course.

Instructors can not determine which role a learner will take on as they are engaging with the curriculum. **But** instructors can *expand the dimensions* you provide in their learning experience and *widen the scope* of perspectives. The roles **should not** be conceptualized as a hierarchical set of competencies. Yet, **each role is contributing** to the meaning making process **in its own unique way**.

The purpose of this review is to explore in what ways, if at all, can you **open up the interpretive space** you provide as the instructor **through the expectations** you set, the **responses you endorse** and support, the **text you select** to **expand students' interpretative repertoires** and the **strategies you demonstrate** during **instructional opportunities**.

Learner Roles



1. **Navigator** - How do I crack the (disciplinary) code?
2. **Interpreter** - What does this mean to me?
3. **Designer** - What do I do with this information?
4. **Interrogator** - What does this content allow me to see?

For each learner role we examine: Purpose, Relevance, Success Criteria, Skills Supported

Learner roles help us determine whether we are explicitly supporting student skills building through our course activities.

Learner Role: Navigator



Purpose- Give students the ability to access written and visual information and, in turn, be able to interpret this information to give the best chance for effective learning.

Relevance- Students who are able to effectively navigate are more likely to experience success.

Success Criteria- Students are able to use their prior knowledge to deconstruct information presented to them, if they are unsure of information, they should be able to make predictions to develop a hypothesis.

Skills supported

1. Recognize patterns in written & visual information that is specific to the Domain Area.
2. Make links between graphic and textual information to decode meaning.
3. Recognize the context of the information to infer meaning.
4. Make predictions about unknown words to learn meaning.
5. Recognize the appropriate metalanguage for the Domain Area.
6. Recognize the appropriate language convention for the Domain Area.

Navigator



- Pattern recognition– what patterns appear in this data?
- Recognition of salient features– what features are most relevant to our analysis?
Data attributes that are completely consistent or completely random are not going to be as helpful as ones that point to real contrasts
- Keeping with the hospital idea: Taking a group of patient data and identifying patterns and ways that the data can be grouped and interpreted.

Learner Role: Interpreter



Purpose- To be able to create meaning from information after navigator has occurred.

Relevance- To navigate information and see links to prior knowledge and personal worldview.

Success Criteria- Learners will be able to create meaning from content presented and apply this new found information to a variety of different contexts.

Skills Supported

1. Draw on their social and cultural background as well as prior knowledge to construct meaning from the information presented.
2. Compare their own experiences with those described in the information.
3. Relate new information to information from prior learning and similar texts.
4. See their own interests and lifestyle reflected in content.
5. Interpret and use literal and inferred information from content presented.
6. Interpret and question the structure of information presented (text and visual).
7. Recognize and construct different concepts making links to how these may be structured for the specific learning

Interpreter



Example problem: Rocket science

Overarching question: **What are all the pieces that go into a successful rocket launch?**

- Design: the rocket has to be able to propel itself with incredible force and accuracy, survive exiting and re-entering Earth's atmosphere, and be liveable for the astronauts
 - Construction: using proper materials, being precise in measuring and welding
 - Training: astronauts and ground controllers have to be versed on a variety of procedures and prepared for all scenarios (Apollo 11 vs. Apollo 13)
 - Calculation: how much fuel is required, what path should the rocket take to reach its destination, how will gravitational forces impact its trajectory, how will the weather at launch affect the mission
 - Communication: a line has to be maintained between ground control and the astronauts, even as the latter are in space
- Used as an analogy for modular design in computer science, breaking down a problem into its constituent pieces– also, how can computers and automation help with each of these stages?
 - Generalize to other cases where technology has to work optimally in a variety of capacities, e.g. in a hospital setting or throughout a university

Learner Role: Designer



Purpose- The creation of a product which directly relates to the information presented.

Relevance- Real life application of the information taught.

Success Criteria- The quality of the product produced against a set of criteria.

Skills Supported

1. Understand form and mode of the relevant Domain Area.
2. Create products that adhere to the forms and conventions of the Learning Domain.
3. Understand the purpose of the content presented and the content created.
4. Use appropriate metalanguage for the relevant form, audience and purpose chosen.
5. Apply the skills and relevant context for the content provided.
6. Assess interpretations of content.

Designer



Creating **Multimodal** representations such as:

- Diagrams
- Sketches
- Photographs
- Images
- Presentation
- Journals
- Video Recordings
- Infographics

Learner Role: Interrogator



Purpose- To encourage students to engage with content in an analytical manner.

Relevance- To enable students to understand views, values and interpretations of information presented.

Success Criteria- To give students the ability to be mindful of the context in which the information is presented.

Skills Supported

1. Identify the way/s in which information and ideas are presented for a particular audience.
2. Understand how content is constructed according to the values, views and interests of the writer/speaker/creator.
3. Recognize opinions, bias and preconceptions.
4. Understand social and cultural concepts that influence ideas, information and content.
5. Recognize that the writer, speaker or creator aims to influence others and elicit a response.

Interrogator



Examining and evaluating claims:

- In whatever articles are deemed most relevant to the themes of Week 1, the students could be asked to evaluate what the theses of the authors are, and list both merits and potential limitations of their arguments
 - This shows that the student's own thinking is seen as valuable, and that the texts/lessons are not infallible scripture

Reviewing Your Current Curriculum (Learner Roles)



Directions: In this part of the review, we are going to focus on the learner roles within your course.

The 4 learner roles are: **Navigator, Interpreter, Designer, Interrogator.**

1. Look through your syllabus and for each week label which learner role is being supported in the activities in which you have the students engage. These activities can include in-class activities as well as homework assignments, etc.
2. If there is not a learner role that matches. **DO NOT ADD ONE!!**
3. Once you have completed let's discuss with the team *what you noticed* and *what changes* (if any) would like to make to the Big Ideas and/or Learning Goal and/or Learner Roles.